midfield player but by people wearing St George's crosses and England replica shirts. Perhaps people, now, could understand why I'd reacted even if what I'd done hadn't been right. I'd been pushed—for two years now—and I'd snapped. I think there were writers and supporters alike who decided that I'd been pushed far enough and deserved the backing Kevin was giving me. Almost straight away, I could sense a change in the media and the public's attitude towards me.

I know, sometimes, your memory plays tricks. Things don't always happen as quickly or as dramatically as you remember them. But, after Eindhoven, I know for a fact that things changed almost overnight. What happened when we came out to warm up before the Germany game I'll never forget. Since being sent off against Argentina, England fans hadn't needed much prompting to turn against me. Playing my club soccer for United didn't help. Especially in the old days at Wembley, all the United lads had got used to the abuse. Some supporters used to boo when Gary or Phil Neville's names were announced in the team. The ridicule we'd get at away games for our club used to carry on when we turned out for our country. That all changed, for me at least, in Charleroi.

Five days after we'd lost to Portugal, we were playing Germany in a tiny stadium in a tiny Belgian town. I know there were crowd problems in the main square but we were kept away from all that and the important thing for us was the atmosphere inside the ground. It felt like a little league ground, with the crowd right next to the field and the noise was fantastic, most of it from the England fans. The place was already packed when we came out to warm up about 35 minutes before kick-off. It was an amazing moment for me. I jogged down towards our supporters and, for the first time ever, I heard them singing:

'One David Beckham. There's only one David Beckham…'

It sends a shiver down my spine remembering it now. At the time, I couldn't believe I was hearing it. Like I say, I'm an England supporter as well as an England player: our fans chanting my name meant the world to me. Just like the crowd at Old Trafford had helped me put Saint-Etienne behind me, those supporters in Charleroi made me forget all about what had happened after the Portugal game the previous Monday. It made such a difference, knowing our own crowd—the people who pay good money to come out to major tournaments and follow the England team—were on my side. From that afternoon on, I believe attitudes towards me changed. I'll never know how important Kevin's backing was, but I really believe that events in Eindhoven